

Understanding My Mind:

A Psychoeducation Worksheet

Name: _____ Date: _____

1. What Is Happening in My Mind?

You may have noticed that certain thoughts keep coming into your mind - thoughts that feel disturbing, scary, or 'wrong.' These thoughts feel SO real and important that you feel you MUST do something about them. So you perform certain actions (or think certain thoughts) to feel better. And it works! ...for a little while. But then the thoughts come back, often stronger than before.

This is NOT a sign that something is wrong with your character or morals. This is a PATTERN - and patterns can be changed.

KEY POINT: The problem is NOT the thoughts themselves (everyone has strange/scary thoughts). The problem is the CYCLE that gets created when we try to fight or fix these thoughts.

2. The Cycle That Keeps You Stuck

Here is exactly how this pattern works. Understanding this cycle is the FIRST step to breaking free:

STEP 1: INTRUSIVE THOUGHT (Obsession)

An unwanted thought, image, or urge enters your mind

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STEP 2: DISTRESS / ANXIETY

You feel intense anxiety, fear, disgust, or doubt

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STEP 3: COMPULSION (Ritual / Safety Behavior)

You do something to reduce the distress (checking, washing, praying, asking, avoiding)

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STEP 4: TEMPORARY RELIEF

You feel better... but only for minutes or hours

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STEP 5: REINFORCEMENT (The Trap)

Your brain learns: 'The ritual WORKED! I need to do it again next time.'

==> The thought comes back STRONGER. The cycle repeats. <==

THE TRAP: Compulsions FEEL like the solution, but they ARE the problem. Every time you perform a compulsion, you are telling your brain: 'That thought was dangerous, and only the ritual saved me.' This makes the thought come back more often and feel more urgent each time.

3. The Truth About Intrusive Thoughts

Here is something that surprises most people:

FACT: Research shows that 94% of people experience intrusive, unwanted thoughts. These include thoughts about violence, harm, sex, blasphemy, contamination, and more. Having a thought does NOT mean you want it, believe it, or will act on it.

Common intrusive thoughts that NORMAL, HEALTHY people have:

- 'What if I hurt someone I love?'
- 'What if I left the stove/gas on?'
- 'What if I am contaminated/dirty?'
- 'What if that thought means I am a bad person?'
- 'What if I said something offensive without realizing?'
- 'What if I lose control of myself?'
- 'What if God is angry with me?'

The DIFFERENCE between a person with this problem and a person without it is NOT the content of the thoughts. It is:

1. How much IMPORTANCE you give to the thought ('This thought must mean something!')
2. How much you TRY TO CONTROL the thought (which makes it come back more)
3. Whether you perform COMPULSIONS in response (which feeds the cycle)

GOOD NEWS: Since the problem is in the RESPONSE to the thought (not the thought itself), we can change the response. That is exactly what we will do together.

4. Compulsions: Visible AND Invisible

Most people think compulsions are only visible actions (hand-washing, checking locks). But MANY compulsions happen INSIDE your mind. These are just as powerful at keeping you stuck.

Visible (Overt) Compulsions	Invisible (Covert/Mental) Compulsions
Washing hands repeatedly	Mentally reviewing events to check nothing bad happened
Checking locks, stove, switches	Silently praying/counting to 'cancel' a thought
Arranging things 'perfectly'	Replacing a 'bad' thought with a 'good' one
Asking for reassurance from others	Analyzing: 'Am I really a bad person?'
Avoiding people/places/objects	Mentally arguing with the thought
Re-reading/re-writing	Trying to 'figure out' if the thought is real

Confessing thoughts to others	Seeking 100% certainty in your mind
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IMPORTANT: Avoidance is also a compulsion. When you avoid a person, place, or situation because it might trigger an intrusive thought, you are telling your brain the threat is real. This strengthens the OCD cycle.

5. The Way Out: Through, Not Around

If compulsions and avoidance FEED the problem, then what is the solution?

The answer is learning to:

1. ALLOW the thought to be there (without fighting it or pushing it away)
2. FEEL the discomfort (without rushing to make it go away)
3. NOT PERFORM the compulsion (even though every part of you wants to)
4. DISCOVER that the anxiety goes down ON ITS OWN (without the ritual)

This is called 'sitting with the discomfort' - and it is the most powerful thing you can do. When you do NOT perform the compulsion, your brain eventually learns: 'Oh, nothing bad happened. Maybe I don't need the ritual after all.'

We will NOT start this process today. Today is about UNDERSTANDING. In future sessions, we will build a step-by-step plan (starting with easier situations) to practice this new way of responding. You will never be asked to do anything without preparation.

REMEMBER: You are not trying to stop the thoughts. You are learning to CHANGE YOUR RELATIONSHIP with the thoughts. The thoughts lose their power when you stop feeding them with compulsions.

6. Today's Key Takeaways

- ☐ Intrusive thoughts are UNIVERSAL - having them does NOT make me bad or dangerous
- ☐ The problem is NOT the thought - it is the COMPULSIVE RESPONSE to the thought
- ☐ Compulsions provide SHORT-TERM relief but LONG-TERM worsening
- ☐ Mental compulsions (reviewing, analyzing, praying to neutralize) are just as problematic as visible ones
- ☐ Avoidance is also a compulsion - it tells my brain the threat is real
- ☐ The way out is THROUGH the discomfort, not AROUND it
- ☐ We will work on this GRADUALLY - I will not be thrown in the deep end

Questions I have for my therapist:
